

seized during the October 31 raids at 69 of Koda and his aides' premises. The Jharkhand High Court has asked the IT Department to submit a detailed investigation report by November 26.

The ED has arrested Vikash Sinha, brother of Koda's key associate Binod Sinha, who has "confessed" to carrying Rs 40 crore of hawala money from Ranchi to Kolkata on behalf of Koda. The ED and IT, besides the Jharkhand Vigilance Bureau, hope Vikash's "confessions" would blow the lid off the Rs 4,000-crore scam. Vikash is the director of many Kolkata-based companies in which there have been many unaccounted transactions. The ED is said to be exerting pressure on Koda's men, especially Vikash, while seeking him to turn approver.

Warrants are also out against Koda's friends Binod Sinha and Sanjay Chaudhary, but the agencies seem to have given the former chief minister a long rope. Or perhaps they are yet to crack the Koda code. Binod and Chaudhary also represent a rags-to-riches story. Binod was a mechanic

Loose Noose

CHARGES: Koda's friend Vinod Sinha earned Rs 200 crore through illegal mining deals.

STATUS: Difficult to prove until disproportionate assets case is proved against Koda.

CHARGES: Koda's friends floated 16 companies through which huge investments were made.

STATUS: Neither Koda nor his wife Geeta are directly linked to any of these companies.

CHARGES: Rs 2,500 crore was routed through Mumbai-based hawala dealers and invested in Dubai, Thailand and Liberia. \$0.9 million invested in a mine in Liberia.

STATUS: Investigators are yet to substantiate this.

CHARGES: Companies misused survey and exploration leases by engaging in mining.

STATUS: Investigators have little evidence to substantiate this.

while Chaudhary sold chewing tobacco. In Koda's company, they swelled to become jet-setting magnates, buying and selling property, fixing mining deals and running hotels.

The fact that the ED and the IT men have not arrested Koda is a clear pointer that they are yet to gather sufficient evidence against him. However, proving Koda's links with any of these transactions on the basis of confessions will be tough. All of Koda's communications regarding these 'deals' are said to be verbal. There seems to be little or no documentary evidence to back them. They need to show recovery of money or establish direct transactions to create incriminating evidence. But Koda will find it difficult to disassociate himself from his unannounced foreign visits that he undertook with friends without informing the Centre or the state government. The sojourns were allegedly to invest and park illegal money. By ignoring the fresh ED summons, citing preoccupations with the Assembly polls, Koda may also be

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